general information phone number listed at the bottom of the laboratory's site.

An operator picked up, and the moment she did I started stammering. I don't even think I got to the end of the phrase "directory structure" before my voice broke. The operator interrupted with a curt "please hold for IT," and before I could thank her she'd transferred me to a voice mail.

By the time the beep came, I'd regained some modicum of confidence and, with a steadier larynx, I left a message. All I recall now of that message was how I ended it—with relief, and by repeating my name and phone number. I think I even spelled out my name, like my father sometimes did, using the military phonetic alphabet: "Sierra November Oscar Whiskey Delta Echo November." Then I hung up and went on with my life, which for a week consisted pretty much exclusively of checking the Los Alamos website.

Nowadays, given the government's cyberintelligence capabilities, anyone who was pinging the Los Alamos servers a few dozen times a day would almost certainly become a person of interest. Back then, however, I was merely an interested person. I couldn't understand—didn't anybody care?

Weeks passed—and weeks can feel like months to a teenager—until one evening, just before dinner, the phone rang. My mother, who was in the kitchen making dinner, picked up.

I was at the computer in the dining room when I heard it was for me: "Yes, uh-huh, he's here." Then, "May I ask who's calling?"

I turned around in my seat and she was standing over me, holding the phone against her chest. All the color had left her face. She was trembling.

Her whisper had a mournful urgency I'd never heard before, and it terrified me: "What did you do?"

Had I known, I would have told her. Instead, I asked, "Who is it?"

"Los Alamos, the nuclear laboratory."

"Oh, thank God."

I gently pried the phone away from her and sat her down. "Hello?"

On the line was a friendly representative from Los Alamos IT, who kept calling me Mr. Snowden. He thanked me for reporting the problem and informed me that they'd just fixed it. I restrained myself from asking what had taken so long—I restrained myself from reaching over to the computer and immediately checking the site.

My mother hadn't taken her eyes off me. She was trying to piece together the conversation, but could only hear one side. I gave her a thumbs-up, and then, to further reassure her, I affected an older, serious, and unconvincingly deep voice